

RAVE CHARLES: 12matt3r

WORLD TOUR

A Charlotte DJ's legacy of
bass, art, and community.



Introduction

Rave Charles: 12matt3r World Tour is organised into focused chapters, each designed to stand on its own. Read cover-to-cover or jump to whatever catches your eye first.



Table of Contents

Chapter 1 Rave Charles Meets the Bass Basement

Chapter 2 12matt3r Matter: Digital-Analog-AI Fusion

Chapter 3 Vocals and Up-to-Four Deck Mashups

Chapter 4 April 21, 2014 Tech N9ne Breakthrough

Chapter 5 Cryptic Wisdom One Take Takeover Tour

Chapter 6 Bass Krew Co-Visionary and Promoter Burnout

Chapter 7 Charlotte Basshead Meetup Charity Launch

Chapter 8 TRIPZY LEARY Cyberspace 2020 and Next Chapter

CHAPTER 1

Rave Charles Meets the Bass Basement

The basement ceiling was low enough for Rave Charles to touch it when he reached for the loose cable above the decks. Dust clung to his fingertips. Somewhere behind the wall, a pipe knocked in time with the subwoofer, and the room smelled of warm electronics, spilled beer, and concrete that had never fully dried.

He had been DJing locally in Charlotte, NC, trying to find a way into the underground circuit. The rooms were small, the equipment was rarely predictable, and a promised sound check could mean anything from ten quiet minutes to a hurried glance at a power strip. He was still young enough to feel every mistake as a verdict. A track that entered too early, a transition that lost the floor, a room that stayed still - each one seemed to confirm that he belonged behind headphones more than in front of people.

That night, the problem was power.

One monitor had gone dark. The mixer lights flickered whenever the bass hit, and the cable running to the deck had been taped twice before he arrived. Rave Charles crouched beside the table, listening for the difference between a bad connection and a failing speaker. The bass came through the main system, but without the monitor he could not trust what he was hearing from the booth.

"You got it?" someone asked from the edge of the room.

"Almost," he said.

The answer was honest enough to sound uncertain. He tightened the connection, stood, and tested the channel. The monitor returned with a burst of static that cut through the room like a snapped wire.

A few people turned toward him. The attention made the small space feel smaller.

He lowered the level and checked the deck again. The music was not forgiving. Bass music exposed everything: the gaps between beats, the uneven gain, the moment when a transition lost its weight. Rave Charles had spent hours building tracks and studying sounds, drawing from the metalcore and hip hop that had shaped his ear. But a finished track did not tell him what a room needed. A room answered with bodies, faces, movement, or silence.

The set began before he felt ready.

At first, he played carefully. He watched the meters, kept one hand near the mixer, and tried to make each transition clean enough that no one could blame him for the room's stillness. The crowd stood in loose groups, talking over the music. A few people moved near the front, but the energy stopped there. The basement seemed to absorb the low end instead of returning it. Every drop arrived with less force than it carried in his headphones.

He changed the approach.

Rather than forcing a larger moment, he let the bass lead. He brought one track in beneath another, leaving space for the low frequencies to settle before adding the next layer. The room did not transform all at once. One person nodded. Someone near the wall stepped closer. A small pocket opened in front of the decks.

Rave Charles noticed it and held the mix there.

That became the first lesson the room gave him: the crowd did not need to be overwhelmed. It needed to be read. He had been listening for the reaction he wanted, but the people in front of him were already communicating. Their movement told him when to push, when to wait, and when a track that sounded powerful alone was wrong for that particular space.

He tried a sharper transition and lost them.

The mistake was immediate. The groove thinned, and the people who had begun moving stopped. Conversation returned to the room. Rave Charles felt the failure in his shoulders before he had time to name it.

He pulled back instead of fighting the silence. The next track entered with a heavier, steadier pulse. He kept the change simple and let the low end establish itself. The bodies near the front began moving again, not wildly, but with intention. He watched their timing and adjusted to it.

"You hear that?" someone said beside the booth.

Rave Charles glanced over.

"The room's with you now."

He did not answer. He was concentrating too hard to trust his voice. The statement carried both encouragement and pressure. The room was with him for the moment, which meant the room could leave just as quickly.

He began to understand that DJing was not only a matter of selecting tracks. It was a conversation without spoken language. The bass was the first sentence. The crowd answered through motion. His job was to listen before speaking again.

By the end of the set, the room had found a shared pulse. The same basement that had seemed to swallow the sound now carried it through the floorboards. People leaned toward the music. The air grew warmer, and sweat gathered at the back of his neck beneath the headphones. Rave Charles worked with what the venue gave him: unstable power, imperfect monitoring, and a crowd that had not promised him anything.

When he stepped away from the decks, the reaction was not grand or polished. It was better than that. People stayed near the booth. A few approached to ask what he had played. The promoter, who had been watching from the side, gave him a longer look than before.

"You can move them," the promoter said.

Rave Charles let the words settle. He had wanted a set slot, but the approval did not feel like an ending. It felt like a door opening onto a room with more equipment problems, more unfamiliar crowds, and less room for excuses.

"I want to do more than play tracks," he said.

The promoter looked toward the decks. "Then bring more than tracks."

That answer followed him after the basement emptied.

He had earned the opportunity he was seeking, but the opportunity changed the standard. A successful set was no longer enough if it depended on standing behind the equipment and disappearing into the mix. He wanted the performance to carry his voice, his choices, and the parts of his identity that did not fit neatly into one genre. The nervous opener had managed to own the room's bass pulse temporarily, but now he had to decide what ownership meant when the room expected him to return.

Looking back, Rave Charles understood that Charlotte's underground venues taught him through their limitations. The basements were unfamiliar and often difficult to navigate. Sound checks were uncertain. Power could fail. Monitoring could mislead him. Crowds could remain distant until the right low frequency reached them. Those conditions forced him to stop treating performance as a presentation of finished material.

He learned to mix bass first because bass was where the room made its decision. He learned to watch rather than assume. He learned that a crowd could be guided without being pushed, and that restraint could carry as much authority as volume. Most importantly, he learned that the live set could become its own form of creation.

That realization began shaping the idea that would become 12matt3r, the brainchild of (sofa king sad boi) Rave Charles. The name held a sense of completeness and substance, a way of recognizing that the materials and elements mattered as much as the finished image. The future collective would bring together digital, analog, and

AI video artists who also DJed, rapped, produced, and delivered genre-defying live performances. The idea was still forming, but its foundation was present in that basement: sound, image, body, space, and the people receiving all of it at once.

Rave Charles did not leave with a polished live show. He left with a set slot and a new personal demand. If he wanted the next room to respond, he could not rely only on tracks that worked in isolation. He would need vocals. He would need stronger control of the transitions. He would need to make the performance recognizable before anyone saw his name on a lineup.

The pressure was personal because the music was personal. The room had shown him that he could reach people, but it had also shown him how much remained unfinished. Charlotte had given him a place to begin, and the bass had given him a language. Now he had to build a voice large enough to speak through it.

CHAPTER 2

12matt3r Matter: Digital-Analog-AI Fusion

The basement had given Rave Charles a set slot, but it had not given him a system. In the days afterward, Charlotte's underground rooms stayed with him through the smell of warm cables, the rough texture of borrowed equipment, and the memory of a crowd that had taken time to answer. He had learned how to listen to a room. Now he had to learn how to build something that could listen, respond, and grow beyond one person standing behind decks.

The question followed him into creative workspaces and rehearsal nights: was he a DJ, a producer, a visual artist, or something else that did not yet have a clean name?

He had begun as a DJ and producer, exploring electronic music without accepting its genre boundaries. His background in metalcore and hip hop had already made strict categories feel too narrow. Bass music gave him a center, but not a ceiling. A vocal line could sit beside a distorted drop. A rap could interrupt a rhythm and become part of the arrangement. A visual layer could change the meaning of both.

What he lacked was not inspiration. He had too much of it, arriving from too many directions at once.

In Charlotte, the worktables around him collected the evidence. Audio cables crossed beside visual equipment. Sketches, samples, rough edits, and unfinished ideas occupied the same limited space. Rave Charles moved between them, trying to decide which part of the work belonged to him and which part needed another person's hands.

"I can't make every piece myself," he said during one rehearsal night.

The statement sounded practical, but it carried a harder admission underneath. Sharing the work meant sharing control. Until then, improvisation had protected him. If a transition failed, he could adjust it. If a visual idea remained unfinished, it remained private. A collective would make the unfinished visible.

The obstacle was internal. He had spent years trusting instinct, and instinct was useful when he was alone. It was less reliable when other artists needed a clear direction. He wanted collaborators, but he did not want to reduce their work to decoration around his music. He wanted a unified performance without turning unity into uniformity.

The solution began with the word matter.

“Everything has to count,” he explained. “The sound, the image, the material, the person making it.”

That idea became the foundation of 12matt3r, the brainchild of (sofa king sad boi) Rave Charles. The name blended the number 12 with the term “matter,” suggesting completeness and substance. It was more than a clever spelling. It described a way of working in which the elements of a performance were treated as connected rather than separate.

The collective formed around digital, analog, and AI video artists who also DJed, rapped, and produced together. Its identity did not depend on choosing one discipline over another. The point was the movement between them. A visual artist could contribute rhythm. A DJ could shape an image through timing. A rapper could change the emotional weight of a section. A producer could leave room for the picture to speak.

Rave Charles had initially imagined the work as an extension of his own live set. The rehearsal nights changed that understanding. The more he watched others test images and textures against the bass, the clearer it became that 12matt3r was not a backing team. It was a creative language with several voices.

That distinction demanded discipline. Loose inspiration was not enough. The group needed a repeatable way to turn ideas into performance. Rave Charles began thinking about the set as a shared structure rather than a sequence of tracks. The music still had to carry emotion, energy, and excitement, but the visual work could no longer arrive as an afterthought. It had to be connected to the shape of the sound.

He returned to the lesson from the basement: tracks that worked alone were not automatically a performance. The same was true of images. A striking visual in isolation could lose its force if it ignored the rhythm, the room, or the people inside it.

During rehearsal, the first collaborative tests were modest. Visuals were placed against bass passages, then adjusted when the timing felt wrong. Some images crowded the music. Others disappeared beneath it. A sequence that looked strong on a screen did not always survive the movement and volume of a live environment.

The failures were useful because they made the collective's philosophy concrete. Matter meant paying attention to what each element could actually do. It meant respecting the limits of the room, the equipment, and the performers. It meant accepting that an idea could be beautiful and still not belong in a particular set.

Rave Charles had to practice a different kind of leadership. He could no longer measure progress only by how much he had personally created. He had to notice when someone else's contribution made the whole performance clearer. He had to give direction without taking the work back. He had to let the collective's identity become larger than his individual role while remaining responsible for its center.

That responsibility unsettled him. The name carried his vision, and the music carried his history, but 12matt3r could not function as a solo project with extra hands. If the collective was going to matter, its members had to bring more than execution. They had to bring authorship.

The shift came through a decision rather than a dramatic announcement. Rave Charles stopped treating collaboration as a way to complete what he could not finish alone. He began treating it as the primary form of the work.

After that point, rehearsal changed. The question was no longer, “How do we add visuals to this set?” It became, “What does this set become when sound and image are made together?”

That question gave the group room to experiment. Digital video, analog texture, and AI-generated imagery could occupy the same performance without being forced into a single style. The collective could move between clean electronic forms and rougher, physical materials. It could carry the unruly energy of the underground rave scene while remaining open to new tools and unfamiliar combinations.

For Rave Charles, the change also affected his relationship with the microphone. The previous basement performance had left him with a demand to develop vocals and stronger transitions. With collaborators around him, those goals stopped being separate from the visual work. His voice could become another layer in the arrangement. A vocal phrase could mark a transition. A rap section could create space for an image to change. The live set could be built as one continuous experience instead of a DJ performance with additions attached to it.

The music remained the anchor. Rave Charles still worked from bass, still trusted the physical response of low frequencies, and still drew from the wide range of sounds that had shaped him. But he was no longer trying to prove that he could control every moment alone. He was learning to conduct movement between people, tools, and forms.

That lesson reached beyond the rehearsal room. Rave Charles had already understood the value of community through his work as a co-visionary of Bass Krew Collective and through event promotion at SOMA Entertainment, Create., and Future Pixles. His experience in Charlotte’s scene had shown him that artists grew through shared spaces, shared bills, and shared risk. 12matt3r gave that understanding a creative structure.

The collective’s first functioning rehearsals were not polished in the way a finished production would be polished. They were better described as coherent. The parts began to recognize one another. A bass-heavy passage could meet a visual sequence

without competing for attention. An analog texture could roughen a digital image at the right moment. A vocal could enter without breaking the set's momentum.

Rave Charles noticed the difference from behind the decks. He had more to respond to than the crowd. He could respond to the visual movement, and the visual artists could respond to the changes he made in the mix. The performance became conversational without requiring anyone to imitate anyone else.

"You can hear when it locks," he said during one rehearsal.

There was no need to explain further. The room had already felt the change. The bass did not simply accompany the image, and the image did not merely illustrate the bass. They occupied the same space with equal purpose.

The success raised the stakes immediately. A functioning crew meant more possibilities, but it also meant more responsibility. Rave Charles would have to coordinate schedules, communicate decisions, and protect the collective's direction while allowing it to remain open. The old habit of solving everything through last-minute instinct would not be enough.

Distance made the earlier uncertainty easier to understand. He had believed leadership would require him to become less himself: less experimental, less restless, less willing to move between styles. Instead, coordinating 12matt3r showed him that his range was part of the reason the collective could exist. The challenge was not narrowing his identity. It was giving that identity enough structure for other people to work inside it.

He would tell his younger self that the scattered ideas were not the problem. The problem was expecting one person to carry all of them. He would also say that a collective was not formed by a name, a logo, or a promising rehearsal. It became real when the people involved could make decisions together and produce something that none of them would have made alone.

By the end of those Charlotte rehearsal nights, 12matt3r had crossed that line. It was no longer only an idea attached to Rave Charles's ambitions. It was a functioning

crew of artists working across digital, analog, and AI video, while DJing, rapping, and producing together. Its first collaborative visuals began matching the bass sets in timing, texture, and feeling.

Rave Charles remained at the center, but he was no longer standing there alone. The basement had taught him to make a room respond. 12matt3r taught him to build the room's response with other people. The next live show would not simply test his tracks, vocals, or transitions. It would test whether this new shared language could travel with them.

CHAPTER 3

Vocals and Up-to-Four Deck Mashups

The first vocal cue vanished beneath the bass.

Rave Charles saw the mistake before he heard it. One of the visual artists in the Charlotte booth had just brought up a wash of blue across the wall, the room had begun to move with the opening blend, and he had leaned toward the microphone expecting his voice to sit above the track. Instead, the system swallowed the first line. The crowd heard the beat, the transition, and then a thin burst of feedback that cut through everything.

He pulled the microphone back and let the record continue.

The room was not the basement that had first taught him to read an unresponsive crowd, but it carried the same warning in a different shape. The ceiling was low. The monitors pointed too far across the stage. The booth had been arranged for a straightforward DJ set, not a performance built from vocals, visuals, and several tracks moving at once. 12matt3r existed now as a collective of digital, analog, and AI video artists who also DJed, rapped, produced, and performed together. The idea was larger than one person behind two decks.

The equipment, however, had not caught up with the idea.

Rave Charles was still young enough to believe that preparation could remove uncertainty. He had spent the days before the show rehearsing transitions until the changes felt physical: one track fading while another supplied the bass, a vocal phrase entering over a familiar rhythm, a third deck waiting with a texture that could

widen the moment. He believed the set would become reliable if he made it complicated enough and practiced every part until nothing surprised him.

That belief had already begun to weaken.

Charlotte's underground rooms did not offer identical conditions. Some stages had clean monitoring and enough space for the collective to arrange its gear. Others had crowded booths, uneven cables, tired mixers, and acoustics that turned low frequencies into a blur. A transition that sounded precise in rehearsal could lose its shape against a concrete wall. A vocal that felt intimate through headphones could disappear into a room full of bodies and subwoofers.

He had wanted every set to feel like a journey. The obstacle was that the journey had to survive the place where it happened.

After the opening problem, he moved through the next transition with less confidence than he had brought to the stage. The first deck held the foundation. The second carried the incoming rhythm. A third waited for the vocal passage, and the fourth was prepared for a short accent rather than a full layer. He watched the meters, then the crowd, then the visual field behind him. The timing was right, but the room made the blend sound heavier than it had in rehearsal.

He shortened the transition.

The crowd responded to the bass returning cleanly. A few people near the front lifted their hands. The response was small, but it gave him something to work with. He stopped trying to force the exact sequence he had planned and began treating the room as another instrument. When the low end crowded the vocal, he left more space. When the monitors failed to tell him what the audience was hearing, he trusted the movement in front of the stage. When a visual change arrived a little late, he allowed the music to carry the moment instead of fighting to make every element land together.

From the side of the booth, one of the 12matt3r artists leaned toward him.

“Your vocal is disappearing,” they said.

“I know,” Rave Charles answered. “Give me the next minute.”

The request was not a rejection of the collective’s work. It was an acknowledgment of the conditions. The performance could not be saved by pretending the room was better than it was. Rave Charles had to decide which parts of the production were essential and which parts could bend.

He brought the microphone back for the next passage, this time entering after the beat had established itself. His voice did not dominate the track, but it held its place. He used a short phrase, then let the instrumental answer. The exchange created the shape he had been chasing: not a song followed by another song, but a continuous movement in which his vocals became another layer of the production.

The next mashup required more control. He had prepared it across four decks, with a bass-heavy track underneath, a second rhythm cutting against it, a vocal recording placed above the break, and a fourth element ready to mark the release. In the rehearsal space, the combination had sounded expansive. Onstage, the room’s acoustics compressed the low frequencies until the two foundations began to fight.

Rave Charles lowered one channel.

The change was almost invisible from the crowd, but the mix opened. He brought the vocal forward, held it for the length of the phrase, and then released the fourth deck at the exact point where the room could absorb it. The visual field shifted from blue to white. The audience moved as one body for several seconds, not because every part of the plan had worked, but because the pieces that mattered had survived.

He felt the difference immediately. The performance no longer depended entirely on whether the venue cooperated. He was making decisions inside the conditions instead of waiting for perfect conditions to appear.

That understanding did not make the set easy. A cable near the booth caught against his foot as he shifted position. One cue arrived late. A vocal entrance that had

sounded strong in his headphones came out too quiet in the room. He adjusted, shortened, and rebuilt. Each correction carried a cost. The more attention he gave to the sound, the less attention he could give to the visual timing. The more layers he added, the more ways the arrangement could fail.

During a brief instrumental passage, he glanced toward the collective.

“Keep the visuals simple on the next one,” he said.

“We can follow the full sequence,” came the reply.

“I need room to move.”

There was a pause, then the visual field reduced to a slower pattern, leaving the music and vocals more exposed. It was a small act of leadership, but it carried the tension he had been learning to manage since 12matt3r began. He wanted control over the performance, yet the show depended on shared judgment. The solution was not to surrender the structure or to command every detail. It was to identify what the room needed and let everyone work toward that need.

By the middle of the set, the original plan had changed several times. The crowd had become more responsive, but Rave Charles no longer measured success by the volume of the reaction. He listened for continuity. He wanted the audience to feel that each transition belonged to the one before it, even when the decks, microphones, monitors, and visuals were pulling in different directions.

The strongest section arrived after he abandoned a transition he had rehearsed repeatedly. The incoming track was too dense, and the first vocal cue sat in the wrong frequency range. He could have forced the sequence and hoped the room would forgive it. Instead, he removed the vocal, let the rhythm breathe, and used his own voice over the simpler foundation. The line landed clearly. He repeated it once, not as a performance trick, but because the first delivery had finally reached the room.

The crowd answered.

It was not the dramatic response he had imagined when he began building the set. It was better evidence than that. People stayed with the music through the change. The transition did not collapse when one element was removed. The journey remained intact.

Understanding arrived quietly, in the space where the missing vocal had been.

THE LIVE SHOW DID NOT NEED EVERY PLANNED ELEMENT; IT NEEDED A STRUCTURE STRONG ENOUGH TO SURVIVE LOSING ONE.

That sentence altered the way Rave Charles thought about preparation. He had been designing a chain in which every link depended on the next. Now he began designing a system with alternate paths. Vocals would have intentional entrances and exits. Mashups would be built in sections that could stand alone. Four decks would remain available, but four decks would not always be necessary. A transition could be reduced without becoming a failure. A visual sequence could simplify without breaking the identity of the performance.

The room continued to challenge him after that realization. Near the closing stretch, a glitch struck the workflow he had been trusting. A cue failed to load at the expected moment, leaving one deck silent while the other layers continued. For a fraction of the transition, the arrangement felt hollow. He kept the main beat in place, removed the waiting element, and used the microphone to bridge the gap. The audience heard a deliberate pause rather than the uncertainty behind it.

When the cue returned, it was no longer needed.

He finished the section with three active decks instead of four, then carried the remaining vocal into the final transition. The sound system was still imperfect. The monitors were still unreliable. The room still had its own opinion about what could be heard. But the set had reached its destination without requiring every component to behave.

Afterward, the stage smelled of warm cables, dust, and spilled drinks. The collective began gathering equipment while the last bass vibrations faded through the floor.

Rave Charles remained near the booth, looking at the arrangement he had built and then partially dismantled in real time.

“You got through it,” someone said.

“I got through the version that worked,” he replied. “The other version is the problem.”

He did not mean that the set had failed. The mashup-and-vocals format had worked onstage. The audience had followed the movement, and 12matt3r’s visual and musical elements had shared the same space without dissolving into noise. He had achieved the immediate goal.

But the glitch had exposed a weakness that success could not hide. His workflow was still too dependent on a particular cue, a particular order, and a particular response from the gear. If the collective was going to leave Charlotte’s rooms and carry the production to larger stages, the performance needed more than creativity. It needed resilience.

In the weeks that followed, he began organizing the set around dependable sections rather than a single uninterrupted sequence. He marked where vocals could enter, where a deck could be removed, and where a transition could be shortened without damaging the arc. He kept the four-deck possibility because it allowed the performance to expand, but he stopped treating maximum complexity as the measure of control. The show became repeatable without becoming rigid.

That was the beginning of a method that could travel. It was not polished, and it was not immune to failure. A venue could still flatten the low end. A monitor could still mislead him. A cue could still disappear. The difference was that the performance no longer ended when one part broke.

Rave Charles had entered the night wanting to prove that vocals and seamless mashups could turn a DJ set into a journey. He left with that proof, along with a more demanding responsibility. The journey had to remain open to change, and the system had to be built for the rooms he had not yet seen.

12matt3r had found its live shape in Charlotte, but the shape was still fragile. Its next test would not be whether the pieces could work together. It would be whether they could keep working when the world around them refused to cooperate.

CHAPTER 4

April 21, 2014 Tech N9ne Breakthrough

The microphone had taught Rave Charles that a live set could survive a bad room. The April 21, 2014 show in Raleigh, North Carolina, would test whether that set could survive a bigger world.

Until then, his reach had been mostly regional. Charlotte's underground rave scene knew his name, and the people around 12matt3r understood the strange combination he was building: bass music, vocals, production, visuals, and the freedom to move across styles without asking permission from a genre. But recognition inside Charlotte did not automatically travel beyond it. A strong night in a basement could earn another invitation. A major stage required something more durable.

He carried that difference with him as he prepared for the Tech N9ne and Freddie Gibb show. The drive from Charlotte to Raleigh was part of the work, not a break from it. Equipment had to be checked, music had to be organized, and the set had to hold together even if the sound system, schedule, or room changed around him. The lessons from the earlier basement performance remained close: watch the crowd, keep the bass honest, and do not assume that a track that worked alone would work inside a live journey.

The people around him were still working within the limits of an underground operation. Time was divided between rehearsals, event work, travel, and the ordinary demands that followed artists home after the lights went out. 12matt3r was developing its identity as a collective of digital, analog, and AI video artists who also DJed, rapped, and produced, but its structure was not yet built for a national touring pace. Rave Charles could feel the ambition outrunning the available time.

That pressure made the Raleigh opportunity important. He was not only trying to perform well. He was trying to understand what the people connected to a larger show expected from him. Timing mattered. Taste mattered. Stage discipline mattered. The question was how much of his Charlotte identity could travel without losing the qualities that made it his.

Backstage, the scale of the event changed the way he listened. There were more people moving through the space, more equipment, more decisions being made outside his control. A major-stage environment did not pause to explain itself. Someone might know the order of the show, while someone else knew the technical limits. A collaborator might be watching the clock rather than the crowd. The information Rave Charles needed was not gathered in one conversation. It was scattered across schedules, sound checks, introductions, and brief exchanges.

He paid attention to those fragments. When would he be expected to be ready? How much room was there for improvisation? Which parts of his performance translated to an audience that had not come specifically to see him? The questions were practical, but they reached deeper than logistics. He had spent years learning how to read a room from the floor of the room. Now he had to learn how to read the structure around the room.

The show connected him to a different level of professional network. Tech N9ne represented a national stage and a wider audience, while Freddie Gibb was part of the same event environment. Rave Charles's presence there gave his work a reference point beyond Charlotte. He had not abandoned the underground sound that shaped him, and he had not needed to flatten his performance into one category. Instead, the opportunity showed that his hybrid approach could stand near artists operating on a much larger scale.

That did not mean the transition was simple. A signature set built around vocals and seamless mashups across up to four decks demanded concentration. Each layer had to serve the movement of the performance rather than merely display technical ability. The microphone had to remain useful inside the mix. Transitions had to land cleanly. The set needed energy, but it also needed control.

Rave Charles understood that a large-stage opportunity could expose weaknesses as quickly as it revealed strengths. In Charlotte, he could sometimes recover from an imperfect cue by adjusting to the crowd. In Raleigh, the consequences of poor timing could reach farther. People were watching from outside his established circle. A missed moment would not only affect that night; it could shape whether anyone trusted him with another booking.

He did not treat that pressure as a reason to abandon experimentation. His background in metalcore and hip hop had already taught him to value force, contrast, and direct connection. His work as a DJ and producer had pushed him toward electronic music without locking him into a single form. The performance had to retain that openness, but openness without discipline could become confusion. The Raleigh show made that distinction visible.

Afterward, the most valuable part of the night was not a single dramatic exchange. It was the accumulation of contacts and observations. Rave Charles had entered the event looking for a way forward, and he left with evidence that a way existed. The Charlotte underground scene was not a dead end. It could be an origin point for national stages, provided he learned how to meet the expectations those stages carried.

The new connections mattered because they changed the scale of his next questions. Before Raleigh, he had been asking how to make his live show stronger in the rooms he already knew. After Raleigh, he had to ask whether the show could be repeated across unfamiliar rooms, different systems, and faster schedules. He had to consider how 12matt3r's visual and musical work could travel, how much preparation a larger booking required, and which responsibilities could not remain concentrated in one person.

That last question carried a cost. Rave Charles had been able to move quickly because he was willing to handle many parts of the work himself. He could DJ, rap, produce, coordinate, and shape the performance's visual direction. He had also served as a co-visionary of Bass Krew Collective and worked as an event promoter at SOMA Entertainment, Create., and Future Pixles. Those experiences gave him a broad

view of how scenes were built, but they also made it easy to become the person every task returned to.

The Raleigh opportunity increased the demand rather than solving it. National attention did not arrive as a finished team, a perfect schedule, or a larger margin for error. It arrived as more possibilities attached to the same limited hours. The people around 12matt3r could contribute ideas and talent, but the collective was still growing into the responsibilities of a touring operation. Its strength was collaboration; its complication was coordination.

Rave Charles noticed the change first in the way he planned. A local set could be shaped around what he knew about a particular room. A larger booking required alternate paths. The vocal microphone had to be part of a system that could adapt if the sound changed. The up-to-four-deck mashups had to remain understandable to listeners who might never have encountered his approach before. The visual side of 12matt3r had to support the performance rather than create another fragile point of failure.

The lesson was not that the underground had been too small for him. It was that the underground had given him the foundation to recognize what the larger stage demanded. The basement shows had taught him to listen when a crowd did not respond. The rehearsals had taught him that digital, analog, and AI video work could become part of a musical identity. The earlier vocal performance had taught him to keep moving when the room refused to deliver the cues he expected. Raleigh added professional context to those lessons.

He began to understand credibility as something different from attention. Attention could come from being placed on a significant bill. Credibility came from being prepared, adaptable, and reliable after the opportunity appeared. A major-stage connection might open a door, but the work that followed determined whether the door stayed open.

That understanding reshaped his relationship with ambition. He still wanted the reach, the travel, and the larger audiences. He still believed in the force of a genre-defying

live performance. But he no longer saw expansion as a simple matter of getting noticed. Growth meant building a structure capable of carrying the show. It meant knowing when control protected the performance and when control became an obstacle to its future.

The April 21, 2014 Tech N9ne moment anchored the beginning of the World Tour timeline. It gave Rave Charles a clear path from Charlotte's underground scene toward national stages and placed his work in conversation with artists and collaborators beyond his existing network. The opportunity was real, and so was the expectation that came with it.

He returned from Raleigh with new connections and a wider sense of what was possible. He also returned to a team and a collective that were not yet equipped to move at the speed the opportunity demanded. 12matt3r had found a route outward, but the route required faster growth than its current structure could handle.

That was the complication attached to the breakthrough. Rave Charles had proven that his live identity could reach beyond Charlotte. Now he had to make that identity dependable enough to keep traveling.

CHAPTER 5

Cryptic Wisdom One Take Takeover Tour

The four decks had become a promise Rave Charles carried beyond Charlotte: no matter the room, the sound system, or the distance from home, the set would still feel like his.

In 2016, that promise traveled with Cryptic Wisdom's One Take Takeover Tour. Rave Charles had already learned that a live performance could not depend on perfect equipment. In Charlotte, a weak sound system had swallowed his early vocal cues and forced him to rebuild the set while performing it. The lesson stayed close as he packed the microphone, prepared the decks, and left behind the familiar rooms of the underground scene.

Charlotte had given him a kind of control. He knew the promoters, the spaces, the people standing near the speakers, and the way a crowd changed when the bass finally reached its body. Touring removed nearly all of that certainty. The schedule moved faster than his planning. Venues differed from city to city. Technical details changed at the last minute. The system that worked in one room could become a liability in the next.

He expected the tour to test his music. He had not yet understood how much it would test the person responsible for carrying it.

The route brought new rooms, new crews, and new distances between soundcheck and performance. Rave Charles arrived with his set arranged around vocals and seamless transitions across up to four decks, but the equipment waiting for him did not always match what he had prepared. A venue might have fewer available inputs

than expected. A change in schedule could shorten the time he had to check levels. A microphone could behave differently from the one he knew at home.

Those changes were not dramatic by themselves. They became difficult because they accumulated. A delayed arrival affected setup. A rushed setup affected soundcheck. A poor soundcheck made the first minutes of the performance uncertain. Each city asked him to make decisions quickly, without the comfort of knowing the room.

The familiar workflow from Charlotte had to become more flexible. He could no longer assume that every layer would be available exactly when he wanted it. The four-deck system remained central, but it could not be treated as a fixed sequence. He had to know which parts of the set carried the emotional weight, which transitions could be simplified, and where his voice could cut through even when the room did not cooperate.

Before one performance, the technical setup forced another adjustment. Rave Charles examined the decks and the connections, then looked toward the promoter.

“How much time do we have for soundcheck?” he asked.

“Not much,” the promoter said. “The schedule shifted.”

Rave Charles looked back at the equipment. The answer was not enough for the full process he preferred. He could either spend the available minutes trying to force the original plan into place or accept that the plan had to change.

“Then we check what matters most,” he said.

The decision was practical, but it carried more weight than that. In Charlotte, he had learned to respond to a crowd that did not immediately give him anything. On tour, he learned to respond to an entire environment that refused to stay still. He checked the microphone, confirmed the basic levels, and focused on the bass foundation. The set would have to breathe through the changes.

When he performed, the room felt different from the spaces that had shaped him. The air, the volume, and the crowd's attention all had their own character. His voice had to find its place above the low end rather than compete with it. The transitions had to remain clean without becoming cautious. He worked the decks with the same attention he had developed through years of bass-first mixing, but the choices came faster now.

The four-deck flow gave him options, yet it also created more points of failure. A missed cue could affect the next layer. A technical limitation could remove a planned route. A vocal entrance that sounded clear in his headphones might disappear in the room. He had to stop measuring success by how closely the performance resembled rehearsal.

Instead, he listened for what remained intact.

The bass still had to carry the set. The vocals still had to feel intentional. The mashups still had to create movement rather than simply display complexity. When one path closed, he moved to another without making the disruption visible to the audience. That did not mean the problem disappeared. It meant he had learned how to absorb it.

The tour also changed his relationship with preparation. He had once treated preparation as a way to protect the performance from uncertainty. Now preparation became a way to make uncertainty survivable. He built alternate paths into the set, kept the essential pieces close, and paid more attention to the physical demands of traveling, loading in, waiting, performing, and leaving again.

The work was not only musical. It was logistical and physical. Long drives blurred the boundaries between cities. Food came when it was available. Sleep had to fit around the route. His ears and voice carried the consequences of every night. The performance demanded intensity, but the schedule did not always provide the recovery required to sustain it.

That cost became clearer as the tour continued. Rave Charles could deliver a strong set and still feel emptied afterward. He could leave a room knowing the audience had received the energy he wanted to give while recognizing that he had less left for the next morning. The old expectation - that commitment meant saying yes to every demand - began to look incomplete.

During the tour, the obstacle was not a single broken piece of equipment or one difficult venue. It was the idea that he could maintain the same level of output without changing how he carried the work. The route required him to move from single-city control to a system that could survive constant disruption.

Cryptic Wisdom's One Take Takeover Tour made that lesson impossible to ignore. Rave Charles was no longer proving that his Charlotte sound could travel. He was learning what had to change so the sound could keep traveling.

At one stop, after the performance, the room still smelled of warm electronics and spilled drinks. The equipment had been shut down, but the noise of the venue remained in the walls. Rave Charles gathered the microphone and checked the decks before packing them away. The set had gone well, though not in the form he had planned.

A person nearby asked him how he had managed the changes.

"I stopped trying to make the room become Charlotte," he said.

The answer surprised him as soon as he heard it. He had spent years building a sound from Charlotte's underground rave scene, from bass music, metalcore, and hip hop, from the crowds and artists who had taught him to read a room. But carrying that identity outward did not require reproducing the same conditions. It required understanding what made the identity real.

The bass had to remain honest. The performance had to retain its emotional charge. The details could move.

That realization became the decisive moment of the tour, not because it happened under a spotlight, but because it altered the way he judged himself. He no longer saw adaptation as evidence that the original plan had failed. Adaptation was part of the live work. The set was not a sealed object transported from city to city. It was a conversation with each room, shaped by the equipment, the schedule, the crowd, and the limits of the person performing.

He carried that understanding into the remaining stops. When the schedule shifted, he adjusted the order of the set. When a technical change threatened the four-deck flow, he protected the transitions that mattered most and let the less essential layers fall away. When the room responded differently than expected, he listened before pushing harder.

The result was not uniformity. It was consistency of purpose. Each performance could sound different while still belonging to the same artistic world.

That distinction mattered to 12matt3r as well. The collective had grown from Rave Charles's fusion of creativity and a deep connection to various artistic realms, bringing together digital, analog, and AI video artists who also DJed, rapped, and produced. Touring showed him that a collective built for live work could not depend on one person holding every detail. The route exposed the limits of personal control before he had fully solved how to share responsibility.

He returned from the tour with stronger instincts and a clearer sense of what professional performance required. He had adapted the mashup system across many cities without abandoning the bass-centered identity that had brought him there. The standout moments were not simply the biggest reactions. They were the moments when a change in equipment, timing, or room could have broken the set and did not.

Still, completing the tour did not mean everything had been solved. The workload had taken time and attention away from Charlotte. While he was traveling, community work continued to need care. The relationships and local efforts connected to the scene could not be maintained by intention alone. Rave Charles had been building a

life around performances, promotion, collaboration, and the growth of 12matt3r, but the tour revealed that those responsibilities competed for the same limited hours.

He had wanted to take Charlotte's sound outward. He had done that. The cost was realizing that being present in one place and serving a wider route were not always compatible.

The tour ended with proof that his live identity could survive beyond familiar rooms. It also left him with a harder responsibility: sustainability was part of artistry. A performance was not only what happened while the microphone was in his hand and the decks were moving. It included the preparation, the recovery, the people depending on him, and the community he still considered home.

Rave Charles returned from Cryptic Wisdom's One Take Takeover Tour able to handle more uncertainty than before. He had learned to keep the sound intact without forcing every city into the same shape. But he also returned knowing that endurance alone was not enough. If the work was going to grow, he would have to build a life - and eventually a community structure - that could carry it with him.

CHAPTER 6

Bass Krew Co-Visionary and Promoter Burnout

The office smelled of warm plastic, stale coffee, and the dust that settled around equipment cases. Rave Charles sat beneath the flat glow of a monitor, one hand on a booking calendar and the other resting beside a microphone he had not used since returning from Cryptic Wisdom's One Take Takeover Tour.

Charlotte's underground scene had not slowed while he was away. Messages filled the screen: questions about bookings, requests for promotion, artists looking for a first opportunity, and reminders about events connected to Bass Krew Collective. His touring momentum had made him more visible, but visibility had turned into a second job. At SOMA Entertainment, Create., and Future Pixles, he had helped promote events and keep rooms moving. As a co-visionary of Bass Krew Collective, he had also helped shape a community where music, visuals, and experimentation could meet.

Now every role seemed to reach for him at once.

He opened one message, answered half of it, then moved to another. A promoter needed confirmation. Someone else needed a graphic approved. A younger artist wanted advice about a set. The requests were reasonable. That was part of what made them difficult to refuse.

"Can you confirm the lineup tonight?" someone asked from the doorway.

Rave Charles looked up. He recognized the question as one he had answered many times, in many rooms, while carrying too much equipment and too little rest.

"I'm working through it," he said.

"There are people waiting on an answer."

"I know."

The door closed. The monitor hummed. Somewhere beyond the office, a case latch snapped shut, followed by the scrape of a table being moved across the floor.

He had wanted the scene to thrive. That intention had not changed. What had changed was the amount of himself he had placed beneath it.

For years, motion had felt like proof. Nearly 400 shows over a 5-year span across America had taught him how to adapt to unfamiliar rooms, unreliable sound systems, and schedules that left little space between arrival and performance. He had learned to keep vocals present even when early cues disappeared into imperfect speakers. He had learned to build a set across up to four decks without forcing every room into the same shape. Touring had shown him that endurance was not the same as sustainability.

The lesson followed him home, but home offered no quiet place to practice it.

Bass Krew Collective carried the energy of the Charlotte underground rave scene. It was a network of artists, organizers, and listeners who believed bass music could be more than a night out. Rave Charles had helped make room for that belief. Promotion at SOMA Entertainment, Create., and Future Pixles placed him near the practical work: schedules, flyers, lineups, equipment, doors, and the small decisions that determined whether an event felt welcoming or disorganized.

The work mattered. So did the people.

But the meaning of the work did not erase its cost.

At another event-prep space, he stood beside a folding table covered with cables, printed schedules, and half-empty water bottles. The air was colder than the office, and the concrete floor pushed the chill through his shoes. A screen waited for visuals

from the 12matt3r collective, whose digital, analog, and AI video artists also DJed, rapped, and produced. The collective had grown from the same instinct that shaped his live sets: combine separate elements without flattening them into one predictable sound.

Someone asked whether the visual sequence had been finalized.

“Not yet,” Rave Charles said.

“Should we hold the doors?”

He looked at the clock. The answer affected more than one person. It affected the artists waiting to perform, the people who had traveled across Charlotte, and the crew trying to build a coherent night from limited time and resources.

“Give it a little longer,” he said.

The words came easily. The responsibility did not.

A second person approached with a question about promotion. Then another asked about a booking. Rave Charles listened, responded, and shifted from one problem to the next. He had become useful in too many directions. Each solution created another expectation, and each expectation made stepping away feel like abandonment.

“Do you want me to take this?” someone asked, holding out a stack of papers.

Rave Charles almost said yes. Instead, he took the papers.

“I’ve got it.”

The statement landed with more weight than he intended. He had said it to protect the event, but also to protect an identity he no longer knew how to separate from constant responsibility. If he was not booking, promoting, mentoring, performing, or solving, who was he inside the scene he had helped build?

That question followed him into the next room.

The event space was not full yet. Bass rolled through a sound check, low enough to vibrate the table beneath his palm. The smell of dust and warm cables mixed with the sharper scent of cleaning solution. He watched people prepare around him and felt strangely absent from the work. He knew what needed to happen. He could see the gaps. He could name the fixes.

He simply did not have the same supply of energy he had once treated as endless.

A promoter came over with an update.

"We may need to change the order," the promoter said. "One of the artists is delayed."

Rave Charles looked at the schedule. He understood immediately how to rearrange it. He also understood that he had been making versions of the same decision for years, absorbing every disruption so the night could continue without showing strain.

"Move the set later," he said. "Keep the transition simple."

"Are you sure?"

"No," Rave Charles answered, after a pause. "But it's the cleanest option."

The promoter nodded and walked away.

The admission stayed with him. He had spent so long presenting certainty that uncertainty felt like a failure. Yet the uncertainty was not about the lineup. It was about whether the way he had been working could continue.

By then, the obligations had begun to blur together. Booking felt like promotion. Promotion felt like mentorship. Mentorship felt like another promise he might not have the strength to keep. His own creative work, once the source of the movement, had been pushed toward the edges. The microphone remained nearby, but he was thinking more about schedules than vocals. The decks were available, but his attention was fixed on whether everyone else had what they needed.

He had wanted to protect the scene. Instead, he had started treating himself as expendable.

That realization did not arrive as a dramatic collapse. It came through small refusals inside him: the reluctance to open another message, the irritation at a reasonable question, the fatigue that remained after sleep, and the growing sense that every new opportunity required him to become less present in his own life.

He returned to the office and shut the door.

The calendar still covered the screen. Names and times filled the grid. He moved the cursor across them without changing anything.

A message appeared from an artist asking whether there would be another community event soon.

Rave Charles read it twice. His first impulse was to answer immediately, promise a date, and begin assembling the pieces. That had been his pattern: respond first, recover later. But the exhaustion had made the pattern visible.

He leaned back and looked at the equipment around him. Materials were everywhere - cables, screens, decks, microphones, printed schedules, borrowed tables, and the physical pieces that allowed an idea to become an event. People were part of that material too, though not in a disposable sense. Their time, trust, skills, and attention were what gave the work substance.

The name 12matt3r had always suggested more than a clever combination of number and word. It carried the idea that completeness came from recognizing what something was made of. Rave Charles had understood that in design and performance. He had not applied it to leadership.

Leadership had become, in his mind, a test of how much pressure he could absorb. He had mistaken hustle for care. He had believed that if he stayed available, the scene would remain protected. Looking at the calendar, he saw the flaw. A structure

built around one exhausted person was not a strong structure, no matter how much energy that person had once supplied.

A knock came at the door.

"You good?" the promoter asked.

Rave Charles looked at the unopened message and then at the microphone on the desk.

"Not really," he said.

The promoter waited.

"I've been trying to carry every part of this," Rave Charles continued. "The bookings, the promotion, the people, the creative work. I thought that was what leadership meant."

"What do you think it means now?"

He considered the question. Outside, a case rolled across the floor. The wheels caught on a seam in the concrete, bumped once, and continued.

"It means paying attention to what the work is made of," he said. "The materials, the people, the process. Not just pushing harder."

The promoter nodded, but the conversation did not solve the immediate problems. The schedule still needed adjusting. The event still required preparation. Rave Charles still had to decide what he could finish and what he needed to release.

He did not leave the room with everything repaired. The night remained imperfect, and his fatigue remained real. Some tasks went unfinished. Some expectations were disappointed. The setback was not only that he had reached a personal low; it was that the old way of working could no longer disguise the damage. His momentum had not protected his creative energy. It had consumed it.

For a while, that felt like failure.

Looking back, Rave Charles understood that the failure was more specific. He had failed to recognize his own limits until they began shaping every decision. He had failed to make space for other people to carry responsibility because control felt safer than uncertainty. He had also failed to distinguish commitment from constant availability.

The distinction mattered. Commitment could be rooted in values. Constant availability was only a condition of exhaustion.

His work with Bass Krew Collective, and his promotion at SOMA Entertainment, Create., and Future Pixles, had taught him how much unseen labor supported a visible night. Touring had taught him how to adapt his performance to unfamiliar conditions. The lowest point at home taught him that adaptation had to include his own life. A flexible set could survive a broken cue or a difficult sound system. A person could not keep improvising around depletion without consequences.

He began to pause before answering requests. He looked at what an event needed rather than assuming he had to provide every part of it. He made room for clearer roles, more deliberate preparation, and a pace that left space for the creative work that had brought everyone together. The change was not immediate, and it was not comfortable. Saying no still felt like letting people down. Delegating still felt like surrendering control.

But the alternative had become clear.

The next community events would not be assembled only because a date appeared on a calendar or because someone needed an answer. They would be shaped with more intention. The purpose would come before the rush, and the process would be treated as part of the experience rather than an invisible burden placed on one person.

Rave Charles closed the calendar and left the message unanswered for the moment. The microphone remained on the desk. The decks waited nearby. Neither demanded

that he prove anything that night.

He sat in the quiet office long enough to decide what mattered first.

CHAPTER 7

Charlotte Basshead Meetup Charity Launch

The office was quiet except for the refrigerator cycling on and the faint electrical hum around the decks. After years of answering every message, every booking request, and every crisis in Charlotte's underground scene, Rave Charles had finally left one unanswered. He had returned from the Cryptic Wisdom One Take Takeover Tour carrying the proof that his live show could travel, along with the exhaustion of trying to make every responsibility travel with it.

He sat with his microphone on the desk and thought about what should come next. The answer could not be another promise made in a tired moment. It needed to be something concrete, local, and useful.

Charlotte had given him rooms, stages, collaborators, and a crowd that understood bass music without needing it explained. Through Bass Krew Collective and his work promoting events at SOMA Entertainment, Create., and Future Pixles, he had also seen how quickly a community could gather around sound. The Charlotte Basshead Meetup had already created that gathering point. Rave Charles began to wonder what would happen if the meetup could turn attention into measurable help.

The idea was simple enough to say and difficult enough to carry out: organize charity events through the meetup and make the support visible. Money would be raised for community organizations. Volunteers would have defined roles. Venues would know what they were hosting. The people who contributed would be able to see where the funds went.

He did not want another event that depended on good intentions and a crowded room. He wanted a structure that could withstand questions.

At SERJ, the planning took place around the practical remains of nightlife: cables coiled beneath tables, the smell of old wood and spilled drinks, and a sound system waiting for the next night. Rave Charles brought the same attention to the charity project that he brought to a live set. He considered the room, the people available, the timing, and the points where confusion could break the rhythm.

“We need the roles clear before we announce anything,” he said.

The promoter looked over the schedule. “The venue can hold the night. The question is whether enough people will show up to make it worthwhile.”

“That’s the part we can’t assume,” Rave Charles said. “We have to earn it.”

The obstacle was not a lack of enthusiasm. Charlotte’s bass community was willing to support a cause, but enthusiasm could scatter quickly when details were vague. Volunteers needed to know when they were expected and what they were responsible for. Artists needed to understand the purpose of the night. The venue needed a workable plan. Funds needed to be tracked without relying on memory or trust alone.

Rave Charles had learned, through burnout, that carrying every piece himself was not leadership. It was a way of making failure harder to see until it was too late. This time, he worked toward shared responsibility without surrendering accountability. He reached out to people who could help with entry, promotion, artist coordination, and communication. He kept the event connected to the Charlotte Basshead Meetup rather than presenting it as a separate project built around his name.

That distinction mattered to him. 12matt3r, the brainchild of (sofa king sad boi) Rave Charles, represented a fusion of creativity and a deep connection to various artistic realms. Its collective included digital, analog, and AI video artists who also DJed, rapped, produced, and built genre-defying live performances. The charity meetup carried that same belief that different skills could become stronger when they were connected. Music could draw people in. Visuals could shape the atmosphere. Organization could turn attendance into support.

As the first event approached, small problems appeared in ordinary forms. A volunteer's availability changed. A question about the beneficiary circulated without a clear answer. Someone repeated a figure that had not been confirmed. The kind of misinformation that could have been brushed aside during a regular party felt more serious when money and community trust were involved.

Rave Charles addressed it directly instead of letting the uncertainty grow.

"If we don't know the answer yet, we say that," he told the people helping with the event. "We don't fill in the blank."

The decision slowed the announcement, but it made the project stronger. The charity event would not depend on vague claims about impact. The purpose, collection method, and final outcome would be communicated plainly. The community would not have to guess whether the night had helped anyone.

That transparency also changed the tone of the planning. Volunteers were not simply being asked to work for an event. They were being trusted with a public responsibility. The venue was not merely providing a room. It was participating in a relationship with the people who came through its doors. Rave Charles understood that a successful charity night would be measured after the music ended, when the numbers were counted and the promises could be checked.

The Charlotte Basshead Meetup on November 9, 2019, at Crown Station became one of the important points in that development. The room carried the familiar physical language of the scene: low frequencies moving through the floor, warm air gathering near the crowd, and the layered sound of conversation, equipment, and music. It was a meetup night, but it also represented a new standard for what the gathering could accomplish.

Rave Charles had spent years learning how to read a room from behind the decks. His live production sets used vocals and seamless mashups across up to four decks, and his experience performing almost 400 shows across America over roughly five

years had taught him to adapt quickly. Yet the charity event required a different kind of awareness. He had to read the room as a community, not only as an audience.

Were people finding the information they needed? Did volunteers know where to stand? Was the purpose of the fundraiser visible without overwhelming the music? Was the energy helping the work or distracting from it?

He moved between those concerns without treating any of them as secondary. The bass still mattered. So did the people who had come to dance. But the night had another responsibility, and Rave Charles kept returning to it.

A volunteer approached with a question about the funds.

"We're getting asked how the total will be shared," the volunteer said.

Rave Charles looked toward the entrance, where people were arriving in small groups. "Tell them we'll report it after everything is reconciled. No guesses."

"And if people want an answer tonight?"

"Then give them the same answer. Clear is better than fast."

The exchange was brief, but it marked a change in him. Earlier in his career, pressure had often pushed him toward immediate solutions. He had tried to solve problems before they had fully taken shape, and the cost had accumulated in his body, his schedule, and his relationships. Now he could let a question remain open long enough to answer it correctly.

The night itself did not need to be dramatized to matter. It worked because many ordinary decisions held together. People arrived. Volunteers handled their assignments. The venue remained functional. The artists contributed to the atmosphere. Attendees gave because the event made participation easy and the purpose understandable. Rave Charles kept the focus on the work rather than turning the fundraiser into a performance of personal virtue.

When the event ended, the room changed gradually. The music stopped, but the floor still seemed to carry its vibration. Cables were gathered. Trash was cleared. Conversations became quieter. The practical work that followed the celebration began.

The funds were counted and reconciled. The outcome was communicated publicly rather than left to rumor. That step established something more lasting than a single successful night: the meetup could be both energetic and accountable. Its reputation would not rest only on who performed or how loud the system was. It would also rest on whether Rave Charles and the people around him did what they said they would do.

The first major charity run succeeded, and the success opened new ground. The Charlotte Basshead Meetup was no longer only a social gathering for people connected by bass music. It had become a model for future collaborations with venues, artists, volunteers, and community organizations. The process could be repeated without being copied mechanically. Each partnership would require its own care, but the foundation was there: clear purpose, coordinated roles, responsible handling of funds, and public-facing transparency.

Rave Charles felt the difference in the days afterward. The messages he received were not all about bookings or lineups. People reached out because they had seen the meetup operate with consistency. They wanted to know how they could contribute to the next effort. The attention was encouraging, but it also raised the standard. A clean win did not reduce his responsibility; it made that responsibility more visible.

He thought back to the night he had closed the calendar and left a message unanswered. At the time, the decision had felt like a retreat from the work. With distance, it looked more like the beginning of a better form of leadership. He had not stopped caring about the scene. He had stopped confusing constant availability with care.

The lesson he would have offered his younger self was not to become less ambitious. It was to build ambition around systems that other people could enter. A

community could not depend on one exhausted person remembering every detail. A meaningful event needed more than a compelling idea and a crowded dance floor. It needed people who could trust the process and see the result.

The charity launch also clarified the relationship between his creative life and his community work. The same instinct that had led him to combine metalcore influence, hip hop, electronic music, vocals, and four-deck mashups had led him here. He had always been drawn to combinations that refused strict boundaries. Through 12matt3r, that approach existed in music and visual art. Through the Charlotte Basshead Meetup, it extended into cooperation.

By the end of the first major run, Rave Charles was no longer operating from guarded recovery. He was building with confidence, but the confidence was practical. It came from having watched a complicated event move from an idea to a measurable outcome. It came from seeing volunteers take ownership, venues participate, and attendees respond to honesty. It came from learning that non-negativity was not passivity. It was a deliberate refusal to let rumor, ego, or unnecessary conflict define the work.

The meetup's future collaborations would carry the evidence of that night. Charlotte's underground scene had always known how to gather around sound. Rave Charles had helped it discover another reason to gather: to turn collective energy into support that could be counted, communicated, and trusted.

CHAPTER 8

TRIPZY LEARY Cyberspace 2020 and Next Chapter

The calendar on Rave Charles's desk still carried the evidence of the Charlotte Basshead Meetup charity event: names, times, responsibilities, and notes that no longer depended on him alone. The pages had once represented pressure. Now they represented proof. Volunteers had taken ownership, venues had participated, and the underground scene had gathered around something that could be counted and trusted.

He carried that proof into 2020.

By February, the schedule had filled again. Bass Planet in Wilmington, the Charlotte dates at SERJ, and the TRIPZY Leary Cyberspace 2020 Southeast Tour all sat among the ordinary demands of performance and community work. The tour would move through Asheville, Atlanta, Charleston, Orlando, Savannah, and Charlotte between February 28 and March 4. It was a compact run, but it asked the same question every tour had asked him in a different form: could the show travel without losing its center?

Rave Charles was older than when he had first earned a slot in Charlotte's underground scene, though age alone did not explain the caution he felt. He had already performed almost 400 shows over a 5-year span across America. He had learned to work with unreliable sound systems, changing rooms, difficult schedules, and crowds that did not respond on command. He had also learned what happened when he treated every responsibility as his alone.

The charity meetup had changed the evidence around him. The work could be shared. The question was whether the performance could be shared without becoming diluted.

12matt3r had never been only a DJ project. As the brainchild of (sofa king sad boi) Rave Charles, it represented a fusion of creativity and a deep connection to various artistic realms. The collective of digital, analog, and AI video artists also DJed, rapped, produced, and built genre-defying live performances. Its name, blending the number 12 and the term “matter,” carried the idea that the elements themselves mattered: sound, image, material, timing, and the people holding them together.

That identity was easy to describe in Charlotte, where the rooms, collaborators, and underground history were familiar. It was harder to protect while moving quickly through unfamiliar cities.

The TRIPZY Leary dates began at The Boiler Room in Asheville on February 28, 2020. The next night was Vision Studios in Atlanta. Then came Charleston, Gilt Nightclub in Orlando on March 2, The Wormhole in Savannah on March 3, and finally SERJ in Charlotte on March 4. Each room gave the work a different surface. The sound changed. The available space changed. The relationship between the audience and the stage changed.

Rave Charles adjusted without abandoning the structure that had carried him this far. He brought his microphone and built his set around vocals, transitions, and up to four deck mashups. The purpose was not to display equipment. It was to keep the performance responsive. If one layer did not connect, another could carry the movement. If the room needed patience, he could hold back. If the crowd was ready for pressure, he could let the bass arrive with more force.

The touring experience was not clean or effortless. Travel compressed rest. Small decisions accumulated. There was always another soundcheck, another room to understand, another set of technical conditions to accept. The old temptation returned: control every detail, anticipate every failure, and treat uncertainty as a personal responsibility.

He recognized the pattern before it could take over.

The previous year had shown him the cost of carrying a community by himself. The tour showed him that the same habit could follow him onto the road. A live production was not made stronger by pretending its creator was unaffected by fatigue or doubt. It was made stronger by knowing which elements were essential and which could change.

At SERJ on March 4, the tour came back to Charlotte. The room was familiar enough to expose his habits and different enough to test them. He knew the local scene, the kind of energy that could build there, and the expectations attached to his name. He also knew that familiarity could become its own pressure. He did not want to perform a memory of what had worked before. He wanted to bring the road home without making the home scene feel like an afterthought.

The equipment occupied its usual places. The decks waited beneath the stage lights. The microphone sat within reach. Around him, the visual language of 12matt3r remained present through its hybrid sensibility, connecting digital, analog, and AI video work to the music rather than treating visuals as decoration.

A promoter checked the timing. Rave Charles checked the set, then looked again at the room.

“You good on the changeover?” the promoter asked.

“Yeah,” Rave Charles said. “I’ve got room to move.”

It was a small exchange, but the answer reflected a larger change. Earlier in his career, he might have heard the question as a demand for certainty. By then, he understood it as an opportunity to communicate clearly. He did not need to promise that nothing would go wrong. He needed to know how he would respond if something did.

The set unfolded through the tools he had developed over years of performance. His vocals gave the music a direct human edge. The four-deck format allowed him to

layer and redirect without losing the bass-first foundation that had shaped him in Charlotte's underground rooms. The show carried the influence of his background in metalcore and hip hop while refusing to stay inside a single genre.

The audience responded to the movement rather than to a fixed formula. Rave Charles could feel the room change in increments: bodies shifting closer, attention gathering, the low frequencies settling into the floor. He did not have to force the response. He had learned to read it.

The night did not prove that touring had become easy. It proved that the system could survive contact with reality. The technical design, the performance habits, the collective identity, and the communication around the show could work together without requiring him to become frantic.

That understanding followed him to Brooklyn Lounge on March 13 for An Evening With Rave Charles.

The date carried a different weight. It was not part of the TRIPZY Leary route, but it belonged to the same movement between touring craft and local responsibility. The room offered a chance to place the work in a more intimate setting, where the details could remain visible. There was less distance between the microphone and the audience, less room to hide behind scale.

By then, the world outside the venue had begun to shift in ways no schedule could fully contain. Information moved quickly, and certainty became difficult to maintain. Rave Charles felt the familiar instinct to solve everything immediately. He had spent years making plans, promoting events, coordinating people, and building alternatives when conditions changed. But the new uncertainty could not be handled by adding more pressure to the calendar.

He returned to the same principle the charity event had taught him: transparency was not weakness. It was structure.

At Brooklyn Lounge, the performance remained focused on connection. The sound carried the force of the live production, but the purpose was not simply to make the

room louder. It was to show how the parts of 12matt3r could remain in conversation: music with image, analog texture with digital movement, prepared transitions with room for instinct.

He held the microphone and considered how far the work had traveled. The national stages, the collaborations, the nearly 400 shows, and the years spent shaping a live identity had not replaced Charlotte. They had given him more ways to return to it.

The pivot did not arrive as a dramatic announcement. It came as a quiet recognition while the set was moving and the room was receiving it. He had been measuring success by how convincingly he could carry the show outward. Now he understood that the more important measure was whether the outward movement strengthened what waited at home.

THE TOUR MATTERED BECAUSE IT BROUGHT MORE THAN ACCLAIM BACK TO CHARLOTTE; IT BROUGHT CAPACITY.

That sentence changed the direction of his thinking. Touring was not separate from community work. It could create relationships, skills, visibility, and resources that returned to the local scene. The collective did not have to choose between artistic expansion and responsibility. It had to design the connection deliberately.

The realization also changed his relationship with control. 12matt3r could not grow if every decision passed through one person. Its identity depended on the contribution of digital, analog, and AI video artists who also DJed, rapped, and produced. Rave Charles remained a central creative force, but leadership could mean protecting the conditions for other people to contribute rather than holding every part in his own hands.

That lesson had consequences. A larger loop required clearer communication. It required rest, delegation, and a willingness to let the work look different in another room. It required the same accountability that had made the Charlotte Basshead Meetup charity event trustworthy. The performance could be expansive while the community work remained measurable.

The March dates did not erase the uncertainty of the period. They did not guarantee that every future event would proceed, or that every plan would survive the conditions forming around the world. What they gave Rave Charles was more useful than certainty. They gave him a tested way to continue: stay calm, name what was known, adapt what could be adapted, and keep the purpose visible.

At SERJ, he had brought the tour home. At Brooklyn Lounge, he had seen the larger meaning of that return. His live production could travel through different rooms and still sound like itself. The collective's visual identity could remain flexible without becoming vague. His community work could grow without depending on exhaustion.

The dates with TRIPZY Leary ended with momentum, but not the kind that demanded constant acceleration. Rave Charles left them with a renewed purpose and a clearer definition of what came next. The next chapter of 12matt3r would not be measured only by larger stages, more names, or greater personal acclaim. Its substance would be found in the relationship between the road and the city that had formed him.

Charlotte's underground scene had taught him to listen to a crowd. Touring had taught him to listen to conditions. The charity work had taught him to listen to the people carrying the mission with him. By March 2020, those lessons had begun to converge.

The decks remained tools for movement. The microphone remained a way to make the performance direct and human. The visuals remained part of a collective language that refused to separate technology from feeling. But the lasting matter of 12matt3r was larger than any single set.

It was the network of people, rooms, artists, volunteers, and audiences that made the work continue.

Rave Charles had gone out into the Southeast and returned with more than a successful run of dates. He returned with a stronger loop between touring craft and local impact, ready to expand without abandoning the community that gave the work its meaning.

Final Thoughts

You now have everything you need to succeed with rave charles: 12matt3r world tour. The techniques and insights in this book are designed to deliver real results when you put them into practice.

As you continue experimenting, remember that mastery comes from curiosity, patience, and a willingness to try new approaches. Use these foundations as a starting point, then make them your own. The best results happen when you combine what you've learned with your unique perspective and creativity.

Start with what resonates most, build on what works, and don't be afraid to adapt along the way. Thank you for choosing this book: now go create something amazing.

About the Author

12matt3r

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Rave Charles: 12matt3r World Tour

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